



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MSN 1924 (M+F) EPIRB and PLB registration requirements

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Summary

In accordance with the United Kingdom's international obligations, the Maritime and Coastguard Agency maintains an online portal for registration of United Kingdom coded 406MHz Emergency Position Indicating Radio Beacons (EPIRBs) and Personal Locator Beacons (PLBs). This MSN sets out details in relation to the registration requirements.

1. Introduction/background

1.1 The Merchant Shipping (EPIRB and PLB Registration and Radiocommunications) (Amendment) Regulations 2026 (and, in relation to watercraft, the Merchant Shipping (Watercraft) Order 2023) give effect in United Kingdom law to the requirement to register specified information about EPIRBs and PLBs with the Maritime and Coastguard Agency.

1.2 The purpose of this document is to set out the matters which are required to be registered by the relevant statutory requirements in respect of EPIRBs and PLBs, and for this purpose includes in paragraph 1.3 definitions of terms specifically used in this MSN.

1.3 In this MSN:

1.3.1 "HEX ID" means hexadecimal identity which are 15 characters for first generation beacons and 23 characters for second generation beacons, and provides a unique code transmitted by 406 MHz beacons

1.3.2 "MID" means Maritime Identification Digits, being the three digits within the MMSI that identify the country where the ship is registered

1.3.3 "MMSI" means Maritime Mobile Service Identity, being a nine-digit identification number made up of the three-digit MID followed by a six-digit identification number

1.3.4 "radio installation" means any radio installation provided on board a ship, including its associated antennas, interconnecting circuits and, where appropriate, sources of electrical energy

1.3.5 “survival craft” means a craft capable of sustaining the lives of persons in distress from the time of abandoning the ship

2. Requirements for EPIRB Registration

2.1 In accordance with regulation 5 of The Merchant Shipping (EPIRB and PLB Registration and Radiocommunications) (Amendment) Regulations 2026 (and, in relation to watercraft, in accordance with regulation 5 of the 2026 Regulations as it is applied by paragraph 2 of Schedule 2 to the Merchant Shipping (Watercraft) Order 2023), the registered particulars are:

2.1.1 Ship name;

2.1.2 MMSI (Maritime Mobile Service Identity, being a nine-digit identification number made up of the three-digit MID followed by a six-digit identification number);

2.1.3 Radio call sign;

2.1.4 EPIRB manufacturer’s serial number and any locating frequencies and identifiers;

2.1.5 Brief description of ship, including its type, gross tonnage, ship superstructure, deck colours and identifying marks;

2.1.6 HEX ID;

2.1.7 Beacon owners name, address, telephone number and email;

2.1.8 Up to three alternative 24-hour emergency contacts including name and telephone number (alternative contact ashore);

2.1.9 Capacity of ship to carry persons on board (passengers and crew);

2.1.10 Radio installations carried on board the ship and survival craft; and

2.1.11 Type and number of survival craft.

3. Requirements for PLB Registration

3.1 In accordance with regulation 6 of The Merchant Shipping (EPIRB and PLB Registration and Radiocommunications) (Amendment) Regulations 2026 (and, in relation to watercraft, in accordance with regulation 6 of the 2026 Regulations as it is applied by paragraph 2 of Schedule 2 to the Merchant Shipping (Watercraft) Order 2023), the registered particulars are:

3.1.1 Beacon owner's name, address, telephone number and email;

3.1.2 PLB manufacturer's serial number and any locating frequencies and identifiers;

3.1.3 HEX ID; and

3.1.4 Up to three alternative 24-hour emergency contacts including name and telephone number (alternative contact ashore).

3.2 Although not a requirement specified for the purposes of regulation 6(2) of the Merchant Shipping (EPIRB and PLB Registration and Radiocommunications) (Amendment) Regulations 2026, the registration of further particulars in relation to the use of PLBs is encouraged e.g. ship name and description, radio call sign etc.

4. Further Information

4.1 Additional guidance relating to the implementation of these regulations and the registration of EPIRBs and PLBs is available in MGN 665 (M+F) Amendment 1 (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/mgn-665-mf-amendment-1-mandatory-registration-of-epirbs-and-plbs>).

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